The United States typically resettles the most refugees of any country in the world every year (Biddle 2018; Mathema and Carratala 2020). These refugee households will require support before they contribute to their resettlement contexts. Employment is a fundamental way that host contexts support refugees. Only after employment with a living wage can refugees invest their time and resources into the host country or smaller context. Despite assistance from refugee service providers, very few refugees achieve a livable wage by the time they have been in the United States for five years. When Young (2020) studied refugees resettled to Utah in the past five years, she found only eight percent had found jobs with a livable hourly wage, and only six percent had found livable-wage jobs that offered full-time hours.

Despite this difficulty, jobs meeting the household's needs are critical. The United States resettlement agencies, under the direction of the State Department and Office of Refugee Resettlement, encourage refugees to obtain a job as soon as possible (United States Department of State 2021; United States Office of Refugee Resettlement 2021). Refugees receive rent, food, and job search assistance for 30-90 days, in part to encourage them to become self-sufficient as soon as possible (United States Government Accountability Office 2011) . Obtaining a job is one indicator among many of economic assimilation—or becoming economically average with host context members (Alba and Nee 1997). Economic assimilation takes many forms and obtaining a first job is the first step to the other forms. Economic assimilation encapsulates the rates at which refugees rely on public assistance programs (Nam et al. 2021), enrollment in education (Tran and Lara-García 2020), or how refugees compare to natives in taxes paid (Evans and Fitzgerald 2017).

Some refugee research argues for “the blank slate hypothesis” or the tendency for the pre-settlement contexts and experiences to have no impact on resettlement (Clayton 2005; Gold 1991; Tran and Lara-García 2020). Some argue that the reason for these findings is the minimal preparation refugees can undertake. In contrast, Tran and Lara-Garcia (2020) find evidence for the blank slate hypothesis even among refugees who make it into the roles that migrants prepare for. In their study, pre-resettlement characteristics didn’t predict longer working hours after obtaining a job nor enrollment in additional education upon arrival to the United States. Tran and Lara-Garcia (2020) acknowledged this phenomenon may only affect households in the short term. Other researchers posit that refugees need time to translate their experiences and skills for the new context (Gowayed 2022). Refugee resettlement research then assumes refugees begin from this blank slate and begin to amass resources. Resources are holistic. Money, relationships, status, physical objects, and more can all be considered resources. Resources in one area of assimilation lead to assimilating in other areas (Hobfoll 1989; Hobfoll et al. 2018; Strang and Ager 2010). For example, when refugees obtain jobs, they often work in areas where they interact with others in the host context language. This increases the refugee’s language skills, which in turn could increase refugee access to host context information.

Segmented Assimilation theory and other sociology of immigration theories assume that in addition to post-resettlement contexts, the characteristics of refugees should influence outcomes in the host context (Portes and Zhou 1993). This opposes the blank slate hypothesis’s predictions. Segmented assimilation theory may not appreciate the differences refugee households encounter. For example, economic migrants can plan for their arrival, they choose where they are resettled to, and may have had privileged enough positions in their countries of origin to move of their own volition.

I test the conflicting assertions of these two theories by examining whether a refugee can obtain their first job within a year using the Annual Survey of Refugees (n=6,035) and using a series of binary logit models. I find mixed evidence, but on the whole favor the blank slate hypothesis over segmented assimilation theory. I found pre- and post- resettlement contexts mattered, while the attained characteristics of people largely did not.

These results generally support the blank slate hypothesis over segmented assimilation theory. I found ostensibly powerful predictors favored by segmented assimilation theory such as years of education and most aspects of English language proficiency were insignificant predictors in the final model. Refugee characteristics mattered in this analysis, but some of the ubiquitous and ostensibly powerful predictors of economic assimilation were insignificant predictors.

BACKGROUND

Assimilation

The terms assimilation and integration are often used interchangeably among U.S.- based researchers. Assimilation is when groups of people become more similar to the average person of another group (Alba and Nee 1997; Lyman 2016). This broad definition allows for a multi-dimensional understanding of assimilation. Households can assimilate in many areas and not in others (Young 2020). Migrants and refugees become more like the host-contexts as they learn the language, obtain jobs, eat host-context food, frequent the same places, and participate in the same events. To a lesser extent, the host context becomes more similar to its migrants as it adapts to new language groups or incorporates new foods (Alba and Nee 1997).

As I discuss variables and mechanisms soon, it may be helpful to illuminate the loose paradigms researchers use when considering variables that may influence assimilation. One way

is to conceptualize assimilation factors as pre- or post- migration factors. Alternatively, focusing especially on characteristics that can be attained (rather than those that are ascribed) may provide the most promising route for developing policies. Lastly, and similar to viewing characteristics as ascribed or attained, some theories consider the factors as either context based (Phillimore 2020) or the result of capital—especially social and human capital (Portes 1998; Portes and Zhou 1993).

Segmented Assimilation Theory and Insights from Refugee Studies

While there is considerable overlap between segmented assimilation theory and observations from refugee studies, they differ in the importance given to pre-migration factors. Segmented assimilation explicitly considers education and English language ability before resettlement as powerful predictors of assimilation. In contrast, the blank slate hypothesis explicitly asserts that these pre-migration characteristics matter little for refugees. Refugee studies advise focusing on resettlement contexts to predict assimilation outcomes.

Segmented assimilation theory (Portes and Zhou 1993), posits that newcomers assimilate into different strata of American society. Newcomers can assimilate into the middle class smoothly by adapting to the practices of the host context, more slowly by maintaining separation between the host context practices and their own, or into the permanent underclass by adopting a anti-mainstream narrative and rejecting the sanctioned methods of living in the society.

There are several factors which affect which strata newly arriving household can assimilate. When Portes and Zhou (1993) consider assimilation into the underclass, they note that darker skin color, disadvantaged location in the city, perceived illegitimacy of the migration stream, and the absence of mobility ladders in the host context are powerful predictors of an

underclass trajectory. Segmented assimilation theory, in line with the blank slate hypothesis, contends that post-resettlement factors such as enrolling in training or English programs, the response from the host context, or the availability of housing and jobs in the locale will shape where newcomers will end up (Phillimore 2020). Having discussed the two theories at large, I now provide the justification for my first hypothesis.

Hypothesis 1) Households with Advantaged Pre-Resettlement Education and English Proficiency Backgrounds Should Have Higher Odds of Obtaining a Job Within the First Year

The sociology of immigration notes the importance of education, work, social capital, and other pre-resettlement characteristics (Alba and Nee 1997; Menjívar 1997). Education and host language proficiency are special variables in this literature. In work revolving around the U.S., English language proficiency is how households interact with the environment, accesses its information and harnessing its opportunities in an informed way (Portes 1998; Putnam 2001). Many opportunities are only available to households that can use the language (Korac 2003; Szreter and Woolcock 2004).

The blank slate hypothesis often seen in refugee studies and the sociology of immigration's segmented assimilation theory both assert that human capital will affect assimilation. However, the blank slate hypothesis posits that resettlement resets human capital and only human capital earned after resettlement will affect assimilation outcomes, contradicting hypothesis 1. Previous human capital or other experience does not translate into the new context and so new resources must be earned.

Many researchers observe predictive power for education or work experience (Avent-Holt and Tomaskovic-Devey 2014; Kim, Tamborini, and Sakamoto 2018) affecting even the trajectories of subsequent generations (Feliciano and Lanuza 2017; Potochnick and Hall 2021).

While both the blank slate and segmented assimilation paradigms assert the importance of human capital, segmented assimilation, and other work from the sociology of immigration asserts that lifetime human capital will affect outcomes.

The blank slate hypothesis posits that human capital is negated. "(refugees') context of reception on arrival in the U.S. effectively renders them (blank slates), at least in the short term" (Tran and Lara-Garcia 2020, 142). This paradox can be tested with hypothesis 1) Households with advantaged pre-resettlement education and English proficiency backgrounds should have higher odds of obtaining a job within the first year. If hypothesis 1 is supported, this supports segmented assimilation theory.

Hypothesis 2a: Pre-resettlement Backgrounds that Fit Host Context Preferences Should Have Higher Odds of Finding a Job Within the First Year

Refugee studies and the sociology of immigration both agree that newcomer outcomes can differ by reception by the host context (Phillimore 2020; Portes and Zhou 1993; Zhou 1997). Some resettlement streams are seen as more legitimate than others. For example, Portes and Zhou (1993) point toward the differing receptions 1960's Americans gave Cubans—who were seen as fleeing communism and thus legitimate migrants—compared to Haitians—who also originate from the Caribbean and have enclaves in Miami. Another factor clearly visible in this example is the differing procedures required by the U.S. government. Cubans were given special privileges and supports that other migrants were not—including preferential treatment and pathways to permanent resident status not given to other groups (Blizzard and Batalova 2020).

Portes and Zhou (1993) also describe how in places with racism, like the United States, skin color will negatively shape how natives interact with some households. This stratifies outcomes. Many researchers have outlined the differential treatment and outcomes of different

races in the United States including in migration (Bean, Brown, and Bachmeier 2015), in any task oriented group (Berger, Cohen, and Zelditch 1972), poverty (Van Hook, Brown, and Kwenda 2004) in policing (Legewie and Fagan 2019), and in education (Legewie and Fagan 2019; Mickelson 2015).

Households from favored contexts should have better outcomes than those from less favored contexts. This is reflected in Hypothesis 2a Pre-resettlement origins that fit host context preferences should have higher odds of finding a job within the first year.

Hypothesis 2b: Households resettled to Advantaged Contexts Should Have Higher Odds of Finding a Job Within the First Year.

Phillimore's (2020) opportunity structures identifies resettlement context areas that should affect assimilation outcomes for refugees. They discuss three characteristics of the context that segmented assimilation theory does not. First, the composition of the place itself will shape outcomes. Refugees cannot obtain jobs or enroll in employment training programs if these resources are not available. Second, the relationships that refugees have with individuals in the location will affect outcomes. Interactions with members of the host context are opportunities to learn strategies and obtain insider knowledge. Lastly, the support available in the host-context should affect assimilation outcomes. Because assimilation is becoming like members of the host context, much of assimilation is about obtaining resources like money or housing. Front-loading, or furnishing resources to refugees before the situation becomes more difficult is recommended by refugee researchers (Phillimore 2011).

In the United States, characteristics of the host context should vary across locations through differences in the resources in a location and interactions a refugee household may have

with inhabitants from a specific subculture. Host context characteristics may change across time. For example, 2016 and 2017 mark a transition between two presidencies with different stances on foreigners and different priorities generally.

While both segmented assimilation theory and refugee studies researchers stress the importance of sending and hosting contexts, Phillimore (2020) and other refugee researchers (Betts, Memisoglu, and Ali 2021; Memisoglu and Yavcan 2020; Nolasco and Braaten 2021) focus nearly entirely on context effects. As both theoretical paradigms predict the importance of post-resettlement context effects, I test 2b: Households resettled to advantaged contexts should have higher odds of obtaining a job within the first year.

Previous Findings

Many researchers find support for the importance of pre-resettlement human capital variables, but they find conflicting results. Refugee data is hard to obtain. Refugees are hard to locate, tough to follow over time, and they are often a protected group. Researchers use diverse methods and datasets to analyze refugee economic assimilation.

Many researchers impute refugee status and use general purpose datasets. These results impute refugee status from specific country/year pairs. People who come from certain countries at certain times—e.g., Rwandans in 1993— are all counted as refugees. Some people who are not refugees will be counted as refugees and refugees from country/pairs not included in the analysis are not counted at all. Thus, the direction and severity of the bias is hard—if not impossible— to estimate (Bernstein 2018). Using this method, Fix, Hooper and Zong (2017) found evidence for refugee economic outcomes being influenced by education and English language proficiency with data from the American Community Survey. However, when Capps et al. (2015) found income differences that were explained by country of origin but *not* human

capital, they were using the same data and method. Thus Capps et al. (2015) and Fix, Hooper, and Zong (Fix, Hooper, and Zong 2017) reach different conclusions. Both groups of researchers using the American Community Survey based their findings from calculating percentages, shares of groups falling in a category, and inference of population descriptive statistics.

Camarota (1999) imputed refugee status like the previous researchers, but used the Current Population Survey when they analyzed the effects of education on policy. They asserted that immigration of individuals with pre-resettlement low levels of education, including refugees and asylees, was essentially importing poverty into the United States. This assertion is in line with segmented assimilation theory. Despite measurement error for refugee status, analyses using this imputation method and a long-standing data source can analyze groups over a long period of time and have many respondents.

Using administrative data from New York state—which directly measured refugee status, but only for a single region of a state— researchers (Nam et al. 2021) found that pre-resettlement education and race did have effects on public assistance program use. Those with more education and members of U.S.-advantaged racial groups did better than those who did not, which supports segmented assimilation theory. Like the analyses done with the American Community Survey, this data analyzed assimilation in the long term, while researchers finding support for the blank slate hypothesis identify this phenomenon in the short term.

This study uses the Annual Survey of Refugees, which has many advantages over previous analyses. The survey only samples refugee households and has access to thousands of refugee households. It measures several economic outcomes and is representative of refugees nationally. However, it is limited by only sampling households that have been in the United States fewer than six years. Tran and Lara-Garcia used the Annual Survey of Refugees to model

educational attainment and weekly working hours. They assert "Refugees may not be premigration blank slates, but their context of reception on arrival in the United States effectively renders them so, at least in the short term." (Tran and Lara-García 2020, 142). The survey's focus on initial resettlement characteristics makes the Annual Survey of Refugees ideal for analyzing the short-term assimilation findings by Tran and Lara-Garcia and expanding them to other economic assimilation outcomes.

METHODS

Data

The Annual Survey of Refugees is administered every year to approximately 1500 refugee households. It only surveys refugees resettled to the United States within the previous five years. In 2016, the survey began publicly releasing its data. Combining 2016-2019 data, I end up with a data frame of 6,035 households. The publicly available data is available on ICPSR (Triplett and Vilter 2018; 2019; 2020) and the analysis code is available in a markdown file at (Anonymized).

The Annual Survey of Refugees is sampled from the Refugee Admissions Data System, making it the only nationally representative sample of recently-arrived U.S. refugees. The response rate for each survey fluctuates around 20-25%. The survey is administered by phone in 16 languages, which covers nearly 75% of the incoming refugee population (Triplett and Vilter 2020). The Annual Survey of Refugees includes many questions on household characteristics, economic outcomes, as well as pre- and post-migration characteristics and resources.

Dependent Variable

Included in the data is when a household obtains a job. I subtract this numeric response from the year the refugee household arrived in the United States to create a dichotomous variable

which indicates whether a refugee household was able to attain employment less than one year and those who do not. This distribution closely resembles a Bernoulli distribution around the "not at all" and "within 1 year" levels.

Pre- and Post- migration Human Capital Variables

I use a years of education variable ranging from 0-20 years. Pre- and post- resettlement English proficiency is measured on four-item Likert scales ranging from 1-Not at all to 4- Very Well. Indicators for post-resettlement enrollment in a job or English language training program are also included.

Post-resettlement human capital is difficult to define, but theoretically important. Segmented assimilation theory and the blank slate hypothesis agree that post-resettlement human capital and contexts influence assimilation outcomes. I analyze enrollment in a training program as both a human capital and context variable. Because the rigor and availability of the program are influenced by the context it may be a context effect, however the skills gained from these programs are human capital. These variables are dichotomous (enrolled/not enrolled) and limited to the time of survey. In other words, the survey asks if they are currently enrolled. Theoretically, the English language training program helps those with poorer English skills more and so I tested the interaction of the two variables. There were not enough cases to sustain the interaction effect. I will report the variables separately, without the interaction effect.

I combine the post-resettlement work environments households occupy in the U.S. into service, blue-collar, professional/health/education/social services, and then general support: maintenance, transport of goods, and other basic services.

Pre- and Post- Resettlement Context Variables

Households report their pre-resettlement occupations, and I collapse these into four sectors: professional, sales, service, and blue-collar. Note this is markedly different than the post-resettlement work environments. Refugees typically experience a down grade, this can be seen in the descriptive statistics presented in Table 1. Because most households do not choose where they resettle to, nor have jobs in their preferred sector, I analyze the post-resettlement work sector as a context variable. It is important to keep in mind the categorization of post-resettlement work environment is debatable.

Birth country is reported and used. When information is not recorded, I use country of citizenship or ethnicity to approximate the sending context. U.S. region of resettlement is reported as either Northeast, South, West, or Midwest. This controls for the differences among U.S. regions. More specific data is not available publicly.

I include a variable for the year of the survey to control for changes between 2016 and 2019. I ran the analysis considering year of survey as categorical and continuous. This had no effect on the significance testing of the variable, so I only present the continuous version.

Demographic and Control Variables

Age is measured continuously, ranging from 0-75. Most refugees are young adults. 60% of households have heads younger than 40. Sex is measured as male/female. The number of people in the household is included and is capped at five. I include the number of household members who have a physical, mental, or other condition that has lasted more than six months and prevented them from working or limited their employment opportunities. This ranges from 0-5. I thought to include the number of children in the household, but this was not a significant predictor and so I omit this variable. Marital status is collapsed to married, divorces/separated/widowed, and never married.

Method

I utilize a series of nested binary logit models to analyses whether a refugee can find a job within the first year. I start with a model that uses only demographics. Then I add pre-resettlement contexts, post-resettlement contexts, pre-resettlement human capital, and conclude with a model that adds the post-resettlement human capital variables. Because most refugee households obtain employment within the first year, binary logit modeling is appropriate. Because I am using logit models, the coefficients are not directly comparable from model to model, and the benefit of nesting the models is in observing changes in significance.

To address missing data and to allow comparisons between my results and the results of Tran and Lara-Garcia's (2020) study also investigating integration into American institutions, I use multiple imputation with the MICE (Multivariate Imputation via Chained Equations) package in R. The imputation uses predictive mean matching for continuous variables, logistic regression for dichotomous variables, proportional odds model for ordinal variables, and multi-nominal logistic regression for categorical variables. The predictors used for the imputation are all variables with a correlation larger than .1, but I exclude country of birth (there are too many levels to be helpful in imputation), the weights, and marriage status (there are too many levels to be helpful). I include a measure of public assistance use for the imputation modeling but do not include this in the analysis. This measure is useful for making assumptions about other post-resettlement variables but is not helpful in predicting whether a household is able to obtain a job within the first year. I weight the data according to the household level weights provided with each year of the Annual Survey of Refugees (Triplett and Vilter 2020). I use 21 imputations for each model.

Multiple imputation addresses problems that arise from missing data, but if done incorrectly, or when the data is missing non-randomly, can be a source of error (Van Buuren 2018). To illustrate this was not the case, I provide a comparison of unimputed and imputed analyses in Table A1 in the Online Appendix. The imputed and unimputed analyses are virtually identical. The interpretations of the hypothesis testing and effect sizes are unchanged.

RESULTS

Descriptive Statistics

In Table 1 are the descriptive statistics of every variable considered. I discuss only a few variables of interest here. The four years of survey data are very similar to each other, with similar estimates and variances. Certain groups of migrants only arrive in certain years—for example, refugees from Afghanistan only begin to arrive in 2019. Education had a lot of variation; the standard deviations are nearly 5 years of education wide. Sizable portions of the incoming refugees have recently enrolled in an English or employment training program when they are surveyed. Also of note are numbers of refugees who are unable to work—34% of households in the pooled data indicated they had at least one dependent household member.

Quite concerning are the 2018 and 2019 cohorts to indicating they have an “other” pre-resettlement work history. As this may affect the performance of some predictors, I constructed yearly models to evaluate the consistency of the analysis. The results of this analysis are not presented here but in the Online Appendix. No major differences were observed between the yearly models and the pooled one. Tables for each year’s data is available in the Online Appendix for comparisons. This is a major limitation for this variable.

The average time to a first job is about half a year, though the standard deviation is about ¾ of a year. Many refugee households obtain a job within the first year, ranging from about 44 to 47%.

TABLE 1 ABOUT HERE

Obtaining a Job Within a Year Analyses

I report the results of my analysis using Odds Ratios (OR). Odds ratios are the probability of an event happening divided by the probability of the event not happening. Thus, an odds ratio less than one indicates a greater probability of not obtaining a job than obtaining one. Additionally, odds ratios are on an exponential scale. In other words, the .01 difference between 1 and 1.01 is smaller than the distance between .01 and .02.

Another important aspect of logit modeling is the Akaike Information Criterion (AIC). The AIC compares the relative information lost through the modeling process of two or more models. In this way, it can be used to compare models like R^2 in ordinary least squares regression. However, while R^2 can be considered the percent of the variance in the dependent variables explained by a regression equation, AIC cannot be interpreted this way. AIC can only be interpreted in relationship to another model. This typically relegates AIC to assist in model comparisons. When comparing models, the lower the AIC the better. A model favored by the AIC loses less information in the modeling process and is penalized for overfitting as well.

Demographic Control Variables

When the head of the household was female, households had lower odds of obtaining a job within the first year. Female-headed households had a statistically significant odds ratio of

.35, which is a severe disadvantage and one of the most severe disadvantages in the final model. This should be interpreted carefully. Female-headed households are atypical, and non-random. Many of the countries producing refugees the U.S resettles have gender norms precluding women working or heading the household at all. The number of female-headed households representing this result is small, close to 30% of the sample in each year.

Households with older heads had slightly lower odds of obtaining a job within a year than younger households. This .97 ratio is small in of itself, but this average effect needs to be multiplied with every year of age the head of the household has. The average age of heads of household in the sample tended to be just under forty.

A larger number of dependents (who have a condition or reason they cannot get jobs) decreased the odds a household was able to obtain employment within a year. The odds ratio was .79, which is a modest decrease in the odds. This detrimental effect is typically experienced once per household in the sample, though the model assumes this effect can be experienced multiple times.

Overall, demographic variables were important additions to these models. Of the six demographic variables, only the number of people in the household were not significant predictors at at least the 90% confidence level.

Pre-Resettlement Human Capital

In contrast to the special place given to education by segmented assimilation theory and other sociological perspectives, there was no evidence to assume it predicts whether a household will be able to obtain a job within a year. This finding holds when we control for pre-

resettlement English proficiency and enrollment in training programs but is reversed when we do not control for these variables. Thus, it may be those with many years of education are able to obtain English proficiency quickly after resettlement. Maybe this explains most of their advantage over households with fewer years of education. After accounting for this post-resettlement English proficiency, the effect of education disappears. This is evidence against hypothesis 1.

Pre-resettlement English proficiency also lost its significance after including post-resettlement proficiency. Alternatively, this may reflect a relationship between with finding a job within a year on post-resettlement English proficiency. In other words, perhaps those who were able to find a job within a year increased their English proficiency quickly, as theorized by Hobfoll (1989), Alba and Nee (1997) and others (Phillimore 2011; Strang and Ager 2010). The endogeneity for the post-resettlement English proficiency is hard to measure, but reverse causation cannot be a problem for the pre-resettlement English proficiency because of the chronological order. An experience in the future cannot cause behavior in the past. However, the retrospective reporting is an important limitation of this variable. Pre-resettlement English proficiency was a significant and strong predictor in the second to last model, but not the final one. There is a strong correlation between the English proficiency of the head of the household upon arrival and at the time of survey. In the pooled sample this correlation is .74. This strong correlation may explain why when considering post-resettlement English language proficiency, pre-resettlement English language proficiency is no longer statistically significant.

Post-Resettlement Human Capital

Current enrollment in English or job training programs did not predict obtaining a job within the first year of arrival. Current English proficiency did predict obtaining a job within the first year and this was a very strong positive effect. Those who said they spoke English very well when they were surveyed also had much higher odds of obtaining a job quickly. This is the strongest predictor excluding the country-of-origin variables.

An interesting pattern emerges when comparing the pre- and post- resettlement English proficiency. When analyzed in their respective first-appearance models, only the most English proficient household heads were more likely to have a job within a single year. This suggests a threshold effect for English proficiency. English proficiency may not be helpful in obtaining a job quickly unless the household is very proficient. This presents an interesting conundrum for less proficient households. Should they focus on improving their English or on a different variable that may yield benefits sooner and with less effort? This analysis indicates that neither English nor employment training programs are helpful, at least in the short term. When I ran the final model with an interaction effect between pre-resettlement English proficiency and enrollment in an English training program, I found no change in either variable; alone nor in conjunction.

Generally, these variables added to the model, but the associations and directions of impact, if any, are difficult to interpret. The current skills and characteristics of respondents can only affect finding a job within the first year for a small number of respondents. For the rest, these variables are red herrings. These variables did explain variance, which can be seen in the substantial reduction in AIC from the second-to-last model.

Pre-Resettlement Contexts

The origins of refugees had strong predictive power, among the strongest in the model. I compare the groups in this variable to Cubans, following the example of Tran and Lara-Garcia's (2020) paper for added comparability. As mentioned in the literature review, Cubans have an advantage in obtaining a job within a year, the strongest of the countries of origin. Bhutan, Burma, DR Congo, and Iran are less advantaged than Cubans but more advantaged than those from Somalia, Syria, Thailand, Ukraine, or El Salvador. It should be noted there are very few Ukrainian households, less than 2% of the pooled sample.

Some countries of origin are advantaged, and this supports hypothesis 2. Some of these groups have characteristics and origins that Americans see as legitimate grievances, like the Cubans and Iranians. However, some countries with similar characteristics are not advantaged like Ukraine.

In conclusion, the pre-resettlement contexts had some categories of variables that were very predictive of finding a job within a year, but most of the variables and categories in this section were not significant predictors. Whether these contexts were advantaged because they fit host context preferences will be discussed in the discussion. Additionally, the AIC went down nearly 2,000 points, indicating the power of using contexts to predict obtaining a job within a year.

Post-Resettlement Context

Households resettled to the South had higher odds of obtaining a job within a year than those resettled to the West. This is a slight advantage, underscored by a small reduction in the AIC: less than 50 points. It is possible that these aggregate regions mask some of the predictive power of region by combining so many resettlement regions together. My temporal measure for

which year the survey is administered also was not a significant predictor. This indicates no evidence for any effect a single year, nor a single sample drawn. These results are positive signs for the generalizability of this analysis, and support hypothesis 2b, at least weakly. There was only one slightly advantaged resettlement region, and no evidence of changes in the host context across time. In line with this reasoning, this model only slightly improved the AIC over the previous model.

TABLE 2 ABOUT HERE

DISCUSSION

I set out to test three hypotheses (two of them are closely related). The literatures presented disagree on the importance of pre-resettlement human capital. Theories like segmented assimilation theory and new assimilation theory posit that human capital will predict economic assimilation outcomes while the blank slate hypothesis disagrees. To address this conflict, I test hypothesis 1) Households with advantaged education and English proficiency backgrounds should have higher odds of obtaining a job within the first year. The blank slate hypothesis and refugee studies researchers assert that contexts will affect economic assimilation outcomes and so I test hypothesis 2a: Pre-resettlement origins that fit host context preferences should have higher odds of finding a job within the first year and hypothesis 2b: Households resettled to advantaged contexts, including time place and availability of trainings should have higher odds of obtaining a job within the first year. While both literatures agree on the importance of post-resettlement human capital, I analyze the results of these measures here anyway because of their theoretical importance.

While most of the evidence supports the blank slate hypothesis, there are a few situations which support segmented assimilation theory. English proficiency (either pre- or post-resettlement) was a strong predictor in two models. Years of education was a significant predictor in the second-to-last model and approached significance in the final one. Both these indicators suggest refugees are not experiencing the U.S. context as a blank slate.

Absence of effect evidence furthers hypothesis one (the importance of human capital) over hypothesis two (the importance of pre-/post- resettlement contexts). The years analyzed cover two U.S. presidencies and several immigration policy changes, such as the so-called Muslim Travel Ban. Despite the diversity of policy and political figure heads, no particular year nor the progression into the Trump presidency affected the odds of a household obtaining a job within a year. This supports hypothesis one.

The majority of results support hypothesis two over hypothesis one. In contrast to the special place given to education, there was insufficient evidence that education predicts whether a household will be able to obtain a job within a year in the final model. This finding holds when we control for post-resettlement English proficiency and enrollment in training programs, but education is a significant predictor when we do not control for these variables. It may be those with many years of education are able to obtain English proficiency after resettlement quickly, and maybe this explains most of their advantage over households with fewer years of education.

To explore the effect of education, I included a measure that subtracted the respondent's years of education from the average years of education in the origin country. This measure is co-linear with years of education and performed similarly: no significant effect in the full model.

When considering the effect of pre-resettlement English proficiency, I found that pre-resettlement English, like education, was not a significant predictor in the final model. Both

findings together contradict the entirety of hypothesis one. In the second to final model however, both variables are significant and strong predictors of finding a job within a year and these findings support the entirety of hypothesis one. To adjudicate between these two findings, there are some considerations to consider.

The first consideration is the inclusion of post-resettlement human capital variables in the first place. While those growing their skills may have obtained their jobs before their training, some households may have increased their proficiency after obtaining a job within a year. Using enrollment in a job training program to illustrate this argument, 56 households in the pooled sample were enrolled in job training while being entirely unemployed. 56 households may not be a meaningful number considering the number of unemployed households in the sample: 1300. Such a low number of unemployed households working on their post-resettlement human capital hints at endogeneity between post-resettlement human capital predictors and finding a job within the first year.

English proficiency at time of survey also likely has some endogeneity. It is theorized by new assimilation theory (Alba and Nee 1997) and refugee studies researchers (Strang and Ager 2010) that obtaining some form of assimilation (e.g. assimilating into the labor market) will enable gains in other forms of assimilation, perhaps English language proficiency in this case. 79 out of 855 households rated themselves as speaking English very well but not having any employment. Again, this simply illustrates the possibilities of both pathways: It may be that those who obtain jobs speak English very well after or before employment. Likely both pathways happen. Fortunately for this study, both theoretical paradigms recognize the importance of post-resettlement human capital and so the importance of these variables is not questioned nor tested.

The important thing is how the inclusion of these variables shape the focus of hypothesis one: the pre-resettlement human capital.

Because both pre-resettlement human capitals variables were significant and strong predictors before the inclusion of post-resettlement human capital, it is tempting to consider hypothesis one supported. The loss of significance can be explained by introducing additional correlated variables that explain the same association. Is this likely? The answer may be in the AIC. Introducing the post-resettlement human capital variables reduced the AIC by 706 points. Introducing the pre-resettlement variable only reduced the AIC by about 200 points. This supports the idea that most of the predictive power of the post- resettlement human capital variables is independent from variables inside the model already. Despite this support, the inability to clearly see the interaction is a key limitation of this analysis. This murkiness seems to recommend caution in asserting against the null hypothesis. The final model has unique explanatory power without significant contributions from any pre-resettlement human capital variables.

Hypothesis 2a posits that there will be some contextual effects that will benefit households from those contexts. Possible candidates for this analysis were country of origin and pre-resettlement work sector. In considering country of origin, some origins were more likely than others to obtain a job within the first year: Cubans, DR Congolese, Bhutanese, and Burmese. The fact that the only African country explicitly analyzed in this study is in the advantaged category is an interesting finding considering the large body of literature cataloging the disadvantages of black skin and African ancestry on outcomes in the United States. It is possible that DR Congolese are assessed separately from African-Americans or excel despite racism and a hostile host context through some cultural practices. Cubans were noted as being

advantaged in earlier research because of the legitimacy of their refugee stream (fleeing communism) and tight social networks in Miami. Some scholars like Bonilla-Sliva (2004) posit that lighter immigrants, like Asians, would occupy either a “white” or “honorary white” position of advantage in the U.S. The Bhutanese and Burmese refugees may illustrate this case, but the Ukrainian, Thai, and Syrian households do not. In conclusion, the country-of-origin findings supported hypothesis 2a.

The pre-resettlement work history results did not support hypothesis 2a. While other hypotheses can be debated, there is no evidence to assume that work backgrounds influence obtaining a job within a year. Only the limitation of this variable to earlier years of the survey need to be noted for this hypothesis.

Hypothesis 2b highlights the importance of the host context. The south had better outcomes than other areas and these outcomes were not controlled for by other variables. This recommends rejecting the null hypothesis. I found no evidence that the timing of the host contexts predicted finding a job within a year, not continuously and not as a factor.

CONCLUSION

I found a myriad of pre-resettlement characteristics that impacted whether a refugee was able to find a job within the first year of resettlement to the United States. Country of origin was an important variable, as was post-resettlement English language proficiency. Many of the post-resettlement context characteristics were unable to predict obtaining a job within the first year. These findings supported the hypotheses put forward by segmented assimilation theory over the blank slate hypothesis. The effects of pre-resettlement human capital were obscured in the final model, perhaps by endogeneity and collinearity. This obscuration was in congruence with the

blank slate hypothesis. While most of the evidence points toward the importance of contexts, perhaps over focusing on pre-resettlement human capital, I cannot conclusively support these ideas with this study alone. A model controlling only for efforts made before arrival to the United States would have assumed pre-resettlement education and English proficiency mattered a good deal.

Policy makers should be cognizant of the difficulty refugees undertake to have their qualifications recognized and taken seriously. Investing in English language training after refugees arrive will help them translate their abilities to American employers and neighbors. The strong association of these programs among the employed and recently employed reveal how American employers gain confidence in refugee households' skills. This analysis reveals female-headed households are struggling to obtain employment quickly, as are households with dependent members. The greatest disadvantage in finding a job within a year was in female-headed households. These households may be suffering from extenuating circumstances. They will need assistance to match the rapid adjustment to American living other refugee households are able to achieve so quickly. These suggestions can help refugee households overcome these early resettlement challenges and have their skills recognized by the communities they invest in sooner. Being recognized for the skills and traits they possess is more than treating them with the dignity they deserve, it is how refugee households will be able to provide for their families and contribute to the new home communities.

Alba, Richard, and Victor Nee. 1997. “Rethinking Assimilation Theory for a New Era of Immigration.” *International Migration Review* 31 (4): 826–74. https://doi.org/10.1177/019791839703100403.

Avent-Holt, Dustin, and Donald Tomaskovic-Devey. 2014. “A Relational Theory of Earnings Inequality.” *American Behavioral Scientist* 58 (3): 379–99. https://doi.org/10.1177/0002764213503337.

Bean, Frank D., Susan K. Brown, and James D. Bachmeier. 2015. *Parents Without Papers: The Progress and Pitfalls of Mexican American Integration*. New York: Russell Sage Foundation. https://muse.jhu.edu/book/41531.

Berger, Joseph, Bernard P. Cohen, and Morris Zelditch. 1972. “Status Characteristics and Social Interaction.” *American Sociological Review* 37 (3): 241–55. https://doi.org/10.2307/2093465.

Bernstein, Hamutal. 2018. “Bringing Evidence to the Refugee Integration Debate.” *Urban Institute*, April 5, 2018. https://www.urban.org/research/publication/bringing-evidence-refugee-integration-debate.

Betts, Alexander, Fulya Memisoglu, and Ali Ali. 2021. “What Difference Do Mayors Make? The Role of Municipal Authorities in Turkey and Lebanon’s Response to Syrian Refugees.” *Journal of Refugee Studies* 34 (1): 491–519. https://doi.org/10.1093/jrs/feaa011.

Biddle, Lizzie. 2018. “Refugee Resettlement Under the Obama Administration: Untangling the U.S. Refugee Assistance Program at the Federal Level.” *Global Journal of Peace Research and Praxis* 2 (1). http://libjournal.uncg.edu/prp/article/view/1655.

Blizzard, Brittany, and Jeanne Batalova. 2020. “Cuban Immigrants in the United States.” Migrationpolicy.Org. June 11, 2020. https://www.migrationpolicy.org/article/cuban-immigrants-united-states.

Bonilla-Silva, Eduardo. 2004. “From Bi-Racial to Tri-Racial: Towards a New System of Racial Stratification in the USA.” *Ethnic and Racial Studies* 27 (6): 931–50. https://doi.org/10.1080/0141987042000268530.

Camarota, Steven A. 1999. *Importing Poverty: Immigration’s Impact on the Size and Growth of the Poor Population in the United States*. Washington, D.C.: Center for immigration Studies.

Capps, Randy, Kathleen Newland, Susan Fratzke, Susanna Groves, Michael Fix, Margie McHugh, and Gregory Auclair. 2015. “The Integration Outcomes of U.S. Refugees: Successes and Challenges.” https://www.migrationpolicy.org/research/integration-outcomes-us-refugees-successes-and-challenges.

Clayton, Pamela. 2005. “Blank Slates or Hidden Treasure? Assessing and Building on the Experiential Learning of Migrant and Refugee Women in European Countries.” *International Journal of Lifelong Education* 24 (3): 227–42. https://doi.org/10.1080/02601370500134917.

Feliciano, Cynthia, and Yader R. Lanuza. 2017. “An Immigrant Paradox? Contextual Attainment and Intergenerational Educational Mobility.” *American Sociological Review* 82 (1): 211–41. https://doi.org/10.1177/0003122416684777.

Fix, Michael, Kate Hooper, and Jie Zong. 2017. “How Are Refugees Faring? Integration at U.S. and State Levels.” Migration Policy Institute.

https://www.migrationpolicy.org/research/how-are-refugees-faring-integration-us-and-state-levels.

Gold, Steven N. 1991. *Refugee Communities: A Comparative Field Study*. Newbury Park, Calif: SAGE Publications, Inc.

Gowayed, Heba. 2022. *Refuge*. https://press.princeton.edu/books/paperback/9780691203843/refuge.

Kim, ChangHwan, Christopher R. Tamborini, and Arthur Sakamoto. 2018. "The Sources of Life Chances: Does Education, Class Category, Occupation, or Short-Term Earnings Predict 20-Year Long-Term Earnings?" *Sociological Science* 5 (March): 206–33. https://doi.org/10.15195/v5.a9.

Korac, Maja. 2003. "Integration and How We Facilitate It: A Comparative Study of the Settlement Experiences of Refugees in Italy and the Netherlands." *Sociology* 37 (1): 51–68. https://doi.org/10.1177/0038038503037001387.

Legewie, Joscha, and Jeffrey Fagan. 2019. "Aggressive Policing and the Educational Performance of Minority Youth." *American Sociological Review* 84 (2): 220–47. https://doi.org/10.1177/0003122419826020.

Lyman, Stanford M. 2016. "The Race Relations Cycle of Robert E. Park:" *Pacific Sociological Review*, August. https://doi.org/10.2307/1388520.

Mathema, Silva, and Sofia Carratala. 2020. "Rebuilding the U.S. Refugee Program for the 21st Century." Center for American Progress. https://cdn.americanprogress.org/content/uploads/2020/10/23132117/RefugeeResettlement-report.pdf.

Memisoglu, Fulya, and Basak Yavcan. 2020. “Beyond Ideology-a Comparative Analysis of How Local Governance Can Expand National Integration Policy: The Case of Syrian Refugees in Istanbul.” *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*. https://doi.org/10.1080/1369183X.2020.1819780.

Menjívar, Cecilia. 1997. “Immigrant Kinship Networks and the Impact of the Receiving Context: Salvadorans in San Francisco in the Early 1990s.” *Social Problems* 44 (1): 104–23. https://doi.org/10.2307/3096876.

Mickelson, Roslyn Arlin. 2015. “The Cumulative Disadvantages of First- and Second-Generation Segregation for Middle School Achievement.” *American Educational Research Journal* 52 (4): 657–92. https://doi.org/10.3102/0002831215587933.

Nam, Yunju, Amanda Hausmann, Wooksoo Kim, and Sarah Richards-Desai. 2021. “Welfare-Dependent Refugees?: Evidence from County Welfare Management System Data in Western New York.” *Journal of Immigrant & Refugee Studies* 0 (0): 1–14. https://doi.org/10.1080/15562948.2021.1923880.

Nolasco, Claire Angelique, and Daniel Braaten. 2021. “The Role of Hospitable and Inhospitable States in the Process of Refugee Resettlement in the United States.” *Journal of Refugee Studies* 34 (1): 634–62. https://doi.org/10.1093/jrs/fez087.

Phillimore, Jenny. 2011. “Refugees, Acculturation Strategies, Stress and Integration.” *Journal of Social Policy* 40 (3): 575–93. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0047279410000929.

———. 2020. “Refugee-Integration-Opportunity Structures: Shifting the Focus from Refugees to Context.” *Journal of Refugee Studies*, no. 12 (March). https://doi.org/10.1093/jrs/feaa012.

Portes, Alejandro. 1998. “Social Capital: Its Origins and Applications in Modern Sociology.” *Annual Review of Sociology* 24 (1): 1–24. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.soc.24.1.1.

Portes, Alejandro, and Min Zhou. 1993. “The New Second Generation: Segmented Assimilation and Its Variants.” *The ANNALS of the American Academy of Political and Social Science* 530 (1): 74–96. https://doi.org/10.1177/0002716293530001006.

Potochnick, Stephanie, and Matthew Hall. 2021. “U.S. Occupational Mobility of Children of Immigrants Based on Parents’ Origin-Country Occupation.” *Demography* 58 (1): 219–45. https://doi.org/10.1215/00703370-8931951.

Putnam, Robert D. 2001. *Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community*. 1st edition. New York, NY: Touchstone Books by Simon & Schuster.

Strang, Alison, and Alastair Ager. 2010. “Refugee Integration: Emerging Trends and Remaining Agendas.” *Journal of Refugee Studies* 23 (4): 589–607. https://doi.org/10.1093/jrs/feq046.

Szreter, Simon, and Michael Woolcock. 2004. “Health by Association? Social Capital, Social Theory, and the Political Economy of Public Health.” *International Journal of Epidemiology* 33 (4): 650–67. https://doi.org/10.1093/ije/dyh013.

Tran, Van C., and Francisco Lara-García. 2020. “A New Beginning: Early Refugee Integration in the United States.” *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 6 (3): 117–49. https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2020.6.3.06.

Triplett, T., and C. Vilter. 2018. “2016 Annual Survey of Refugees Data File User’s Guide.” Urban Institute.

———. 2019. “2017 Annual Survey of Refugees Data File User’s Guide.” Urban Institute.

———. 2020. “2018 Annual Survey of Refugees Data File User’s Guide.” Urban Institute.

United States Government Accountability Office. 2011. “Refugee Assistance: Little Is Known about the Effectiveness of Different Approaches for Improving Refugees’ Employment Outcomes.” 2011. https://www.gao.gov/assets/gao-11-369.pdf.

Van Buuren, Stefvan. 2018. *Flexible Imputation of Missing Data, Second Edition*. https://stefvanbuuren.name/fimd/sec-when.html.

Van Hook, Jennifer, Susan L. Brown, and Maxwell Ndigume Kwenda. 2004. “A Decomposition of Trends in Poverty among Children of Immigrants.” *Demography* 41 (4): 649–70. https://www.jstor.org/stable/1515224.

Young, Yvette. 2020. “‘Making Do’ in the Land of Opportunity—a Quantitative Exploration of the Economic Integration of Refugees in Utah.” *Journal of International Migration and Integration* 21 (2): 611–31. https://doi.org/10.1007/s12134-019-00673-0.

Zhou, Min. 1997. “Segmented Assimilation: Issues, Controversies, and Recent Research on the New Second Generation.” *The International Migration Review* 31 (4): 975–1008. https://doi.org/10.2307/2547421.

ONLINE APPENDIX

TABLE A1 ABOUT HERE